

Learning A foreign Language

GER LING RSSS 114

Summer 2025

INSTRUCTOR INFORMATION

Instructor: Fedoua Rahmaouy

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Office hours: Fridays, 10:00-1100 am Arizona time at this Zoom link:
<https://us04web.zoom.us/j/73941818387?pwd=YHm8HsTDzjpokqNiaqpVfaneAb3c0L.1>
or by appointment.

COURSE DESCRIPTION

The course aims to provide students with important tools to help them become successful foreign language learners. Students will become familiar with basic elements of language such as parts of speech and the pronunciation of new sounds so that they can anticipate and effectively deal with the challenges in pronunciation, vocabulary building, and sentence formation that often come up in foreign language study. Students will also learn about the interconnection of culture and language and be exposed to the revitalization efforts of minority languages. They will be exposed to different language teaching and learning styles, typical mistakes language learners make, and strategies for making language learning more effective. This information will be presented in the context of the wide variety of languages taught at the University of Arizona with some focus on indigenous languages of the Americas.

COURSE OBJECTIVES

This course's overall goal is to broaden and deepen your appreciation for language acquisition and language revitalization. **To achieve this, the course will:**

- Encourage your engagement in required reading and related materials to understand how they connect to learning your target language.
- Enhance your ability to write about course content, including a grammar sketch for your target language.
- Guide opportunities for you to collaborate with peers through discussion posts.
- Provide a variety of assignments to challenge your understanding of the content from different angles.

Also, during this course, you will:

- **Choose a target language to learn over the course (and this cannot be a student's first language or a language in which the student is already fluent).**
- Identify the component parts of words: sounds (including stress) and morphemes (including prefixes and suffixes among others).
- Describe the structure of sentences and examine how sentence structure may vary across languages.
- Interpret quantitative data as it appears in tables, figures, and other graphical representations.
- Identify linguistic concepts in your target language.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

These are the linguistics concepts that you will learn in this course. The idea is that this will help you in the future no matter what language(s) you choose to study. By the end of participating in this course, you should have gained and practiced the knowledge and skills to do the following:

- Identify some differences between first language acquisition versus second language acquisition, and how these differences interact with language shift and language revitalization.
- Identify and understand similarities and differences between your target language and others in terms of phonology, vocabulary, grammar, and cultural components, as well as how the form and function of words are expressed in your target language.
- Understand the process of language transition across generations and how it contributes to factors such as language death, language policy and planning, and education within a community.

Non-Content Learning Outcomes

These are the general competencies that you will be working on:

- Demonstrate the ability to utilize multiple perspectives and make meaningful connections across disciplines and social positions, think conceptually and critically, and solve problems.
- Demonstrate competency in working with numerical information by critically analyzing quantitative information, generating ideas supported by quantitative evidence, assessing the relevance of data and its associated implications in various contexts, and communicating those ideas and/or associated interpretations using different formats.
- Demonstrate rhetorical awareness and writing proficiency by writing for a variety of contexts and executing disciplinary genre conventions of organization, design, style, mechanics, and citation format while reflecting on your writing development.

COURSE MATERIALS

All readings will be made available on the D2L course site. This course heavily relies on:

- Culicover, Peter & Elizabeth Hume. 2010. *Basics of Language for Language Learners* (2nd edition). Ohio State University Press. The course will be engaging heavily with the chapters in this book.

IMPORTANT: While this textbook is free and can be found online, you MUST use the copy I have provided below. I have written section numbers in this document that I will use to assign reading chunks. If you download a random copy from the internet, you will be confused when I say, "read section 2.3."

LEARNING ACTIVITIES

This 5-week course will be conducted online in an asynchronous format, with no scheduled lecture times. Instead, lecture videos will be provided each week for students to access at their convenience. The course will take place during the first half of the Summer 2025 session, commencing on June 9th and concluding on July 10th.

COURSE REQUIREMENTS AND GRADING

CATEGORIES	POINTS EACH	NUMBER	TOTAL
Textbook Quizzes	24	5	120
Discussion Boards	100	6	600
Language Puzzles	60	2	120
Final Project	250	1	250
Self-Assessment	250	1	250
			1340

Grades will be assigned on the following basis:

90% and up: A

80% - 89.9%: B

70% - 79.9%: C

60% - 69.9%: D

59.9% and below: E

University policy regarding grades and grading systems is available at: <http://catalog.arizona.edu/policy-type/grade-policies>. Requests for incompletes (I) and withdrawal (W) must be made in accordance with university policies which are available at <http://catalog.arizona.edu/policy/grades-and-grading-system#incomplete> and <http://catalog.arizona.edu/policy/grades-and-grading-system#Withdrawal>, respectively.

DESCRIPTION OF ASSIGNMENTS

Textbook Quizzes (120 points, 24 points per each one). These quizzes have **unlimited tries and time** but must be completed at least once **before that week's lecture video becomes unlocked**. This is set up this way because I have created the lecture videos assuming that you have done the textbook reading. The highest grade will be your final grade. Please, notice the **course calendar has the due date of the first quiz due on Wednesday at 11:59 PM, and the rest on Mondays at 11:59 PM**. However, it said the due date is on Mondays, they will be closed on **Wednesdays** at 11:59 PM. And they will be opened the Friday before the due week at 6:00 PM.

Discussion Boards (600 points)

All students are required to participate in the discussion boards for this course. Each discussion board requires an initial post and a subsequent response to two of your classmates. Throughout the course, you will submit 6 discussion boards: one presentation & language choice; and five study guides for your target language covering a variety of concepts.

(1) Presentation & Language choice & responses.

At the beginning of the course, I would like to see your presentation & language choice posts (60 points). You **must reply** to two of your classmates (40 points, 20 points per each response).

(2) Study guides & responses.

Your discussion board post will consist of two main components (60 points per initial discussion):

- A) A content section, outlining the linguistic concepts of the week in your target language. The resources on your target language can include information from Wikipedia, pedagogical resources, textbooks, Google Scholar academic articles, elicitation from native speakers if you can, personal experience, or any resource available from your target language. You must cite at least two sources of information.
- B) A reflection section describing your experience in attempting to learn these concepts and commenting on interesting things you learned with the course text readings, audio, films, class discussions, and homework. More specifically they will allow you to keep record of what elicits for you a strong reaction/response—whether discovery, inspiration, or stimulation for language learning. These Discussion posts will maintain a running record of your developing understanding and new insights about language acquisition/learning and language revitalization efforts, how they impact your thoughts and ideas, and how they inform and influence your academic and research trajectory, scholarship, and academic identity.

These study guides are formative assessments, are graded for completion, and should be about 500 words total (including both sections). They will make use of the discussion board infrastructure on D2L, as other students will need access to your study guide to complete their compare/contrast responses.

You will also be responsible for posting at 2 compare/contrast responses to other students' study guides (40 points, 20 points per each response). As the name suggests, you should compare and contrast your target language with two of your classmates' study guides. You will complete one of these per study guide, resulting at least in 2 total responses per unit.

The last compare/contrast response (on sociolinguistics) will be different because you will reply to yourself. I will provide further details in the assignment description for that study guide. These are once again formative assessments, graded for completion. The compare/contrast should be about 150 words per response.

Language puzzles (60 points each one). Two language puzzles have been designed to help you engage with linguistic analysis of a foreign or understudied language.

Final project (250 points). Your final project will be a comprehensive Sketch grammar based on your Study Guides for your target language, bringing together the knowledge you have garnered throughout this course. The final project will be composed of revised and expanded versions of the content sections from your last five study guides, including sections on Phonetics, Phonology, Morphosyntax, Semantics, and Sociolinguistics. **As these sections will vary from language to language, there is no defined word count.** When revising these sections, focus on clarity, accuracy, and thoroughness. Your peers' study guides and my feedback are useful resources to refine your work. Although these study guides were initially graded formatively, they will now be evaluated summatively in your final project. Hence, demonstrating a deep understanding of these linguistic concepts is crucial. Do not forget to include the references.

Self-Assessment (250 points) In your last assignment, you will reflect on what you learned from the course materials and reflect on your Discussion Posts, Quizzes, Language Puzzles, your Final project, and your language learning progress. Reflect on your overall learning journey, discussing the challenges you faced, your triumphs, and any patterns you noticed. Consider your reflections from the previous weeks as a starting point for this introspection. Your final reflection should be approximately 500 words. Do not forget to include the references.

POLICIES

Submitting Assignments

All assignments should be submitted via D2L using the appropriate submission method (discussion post thread, assignments, or quiz function). **All documents submitted in this course must be PDFs. D2L loves to mess up Word Document formatting, and I can't open pages files.**

Late Work

Students are expected to complete all assignments **on time**, *which means by the date and time posted in the course schedule and on d2l*. Written assignments must be submitted to the d2l Assignments folder *and will not be accepted for credit in any other format*. It is your responsibility to note when assignments are due and to submit them by the appropriate time via d2l. Late assignments are accepted if you have a medical or family emergency, or religious reasons (as recognized by UA Policy), but you must let me know asking for an extension, please send me an email if you need an extension. If you miss coursework for any other reason, you will lose all points for that assignment. **Please remember that many assignments in this course require peer engagement and feedback, so please prioritize getting things done on time out of courtesy for your fellow students.**

Academic Integrity Policy

We take academic integrity seriously and cheating or plagiarism of any kind will not be tolerated in this course. You are expected to adhere to university standards of academic integrity. Students are expected to adhere to the UA Code of Academic Integrity as described in the UA General Catalog: <http://deanofstudents.arizona.edu/academic-integrity/students/academic-integrity>

ChatGPT

ChatGPT can be useful as a supplement, but not as a replacement for personal learning. While ChatGPT can assist in the basic structuring of written work, relying on it exclusively to do your homework for you is not a good idea. **It often just makes up information, and this can lead to you learning things that are incorrect.**

Remember, language learning is a personal journey demanding active practice and engagement, not a task to be outsourced to AI. These tools are aids, not cheat codes. And you would only be cheating yourself.

I will be looking out for use of AI to replace your own original work and ideas on assignments, as this is not allowed. Please be smart; if you don't want to put in the work to learn and practice your target language, why take this course at all?

Absence and Class Participation Policies

This is an asynchronous course, and as such you are free to participate according to your own schedule. There is nothing really to be absent from. Please note that while this course does not have fixed meeting times, you are still expected to engage with the materials, complete assignments, and participate in discussions within the specified timeframes.

"Classroom" Behavior Policy

Even though we don't really have a classroom in this course, it's still very important to ensure a safe and productive learning environment for all and be excellent to each other. This will mostly come into play with the discussion boards, which will be our primary mode of interaction with each other. Just don't be rude, please.

Threatening Behavior Policy

The University seeks to promote a safe environment where students and employees may participate in the educational process without compromising their health, safety, or welfare. The Arizona Board of Regents (ABOR) Student Code of Conduct, ABOR Policy 5-308, prohibits threats of physical harm to any member of the University community, including to one's self. Threatening behavior can harm and disrupt the University, its community, and its families.

Nondiscrimination and Anti-Harassment Policy

The University of Arizona is committed to creating and maintaining an environment free of discrimination. In support of this commitment, the University prohibits discrimination, including harassment and retaliation, based on a protected classification, including race, color, religion, sex (including pregnancy), national origin, age, disability, veteran status, sexual orientation, gender identity, or genetic information. The University encourages anyone who believes they have been the subject of discrimination to report the matter immediately as described in the section below, "Reporting Discrimination, Harassment, or Retaliation." All members of the University community are responsible for participating in creating a campus environment free from all forms of prohibited discrimination and for cooperating with University officials who investigate allegations of policy violations

Accessibility and Accommodations

At the University of Arizona, we strive to make learning experiences as accessible as possible. If you anticipate or experience barriers based on disability or pregnancy, please contact the Disability Resource Center (520-621-3268, <https://drc.arizona.edu/>) to establish reasonable accommodations.

Subject to Change Statement

Everything in this syllabus is not final and is subject to change. I have done my best to pre-plan as much as possible to prevent interruptions to your learning, but as we all know, stuff can happen. I will make sure to give you advanced notice if any changes are made.

Communication & Content Policies

Communication

I will respond to individual emails within 24 hours of being sent during weekdays, if you send the email on Friday, I might answer you on Monday. If in the event I do not reply back, please send a reminder email.

Civil Conversation

In this class, we will be discussing some potentially controversial topics. It is important to respect all individuals in this class and to create an atmosphere welcoming of diverse perspectives.

However, you should feel free to disagree with a position and to provide evidence supporting your own. Always remember to focus on ideas and evidence rather than attacking an individual personally. Assignments and other content displaying disrespectful behavior, such as name calling, ridiculing, or otherwise disparaging a person or group will be removed and will result in no points earned for that assignment.

Sensitive Content Warning

This course might address topics including human lived experience as encoded in language and other sensitive topics, often leading to valuable discussions on topics, such as indigenous autonomy, cultural sensitivity, and human rights. Course material might include content that is explicit in its depiction of cultural practices, gender and sexuality, and a history of genocide. The instructor will provide advance notice when such materials will be used. Please contact the instructor to discuss any content-related concerns, as alternative materials may be available.

Names and Pronoun Usage

This course supports elective gender pronoun use and self-identification; rosters indicating such choices will be updated throughout the semester, upon student request. As the course includes group discussion, it is vitally important for us to create an educational environment of inclusion and mutual respect.

Diversity and Inclusion

Inclusive Excellence is a fundamental part of the University of Arizona's strategic plan and culture. As part of this initiative, the institution embraces and practices diversity and inclusiveness. These values are expected, respected, and welcomed in this course.

Academic Advising

If you have questions about your academic progress this semester, or your chosen degree program, please note that advisors at the Advising Resource Center can guide you toward university resources to help you succeed.

Life Challenges

If you are experiencing unexpected barriers to your success in your courses, please note that the Dean of Students Office is a central support resource for all students and may be helpful. The Dean of Students Office can be reached at 520-621-2057 or DOS-deanofstudents@email.arizona.edu.

Physical & Mental-health Challenges

If you are facing physical or mental health challenges this semester, please note that Campus Health provides quality medical and mental health care. For medical appointments, call (520)-621-9202. For After Hours care, call (520) 570-7898. For the Counseling & Psych Services (CAPS) 24/7 hotline, call (520) 621-3334.

Equipment & Software Requirements

For this class you will need daily access to the following hardware: laptop or web-enabled device with webcam and microphone; regular access to reliable internet signal; ability to download and run the following software: web browser, Adobe Acrobat, etc. Other software like Voicethread, Google Meet, and Zoom are provided by the UA D2L course page.

Accommodation Policies

Disability Accommodations

It is the University's goal that learning experiences be as accessible as possible. If you anticipate or experience physical or academic barriers based on disability, please let me know immediately so that we can discuss options. You are also welcome to contact Disability Resources (520-621-3268) to establish reasonable accommodations. For additional information on Disability Resources and reasonable accommodations, please visit <http://drc.arizona.edu/>.

Religious Accommodation

Religious practice is protected by the U.S. Constitution and by the University of Arizona policy. If you need accommodation to observe religious holidays, please notify the instructor in the first week of class to make arrangements to cover course material and assignments. As this class is online and allows for some flexibility, you should plan your work time and group work so that you can accomplish activities by the deadlines (you can always submit early).

Technical Issues

Technical Support

Please contact the LHTI office for technical issues at 520-626-HELP University of Arizona 24/7 tech support can be reached at:520-626-TECH

Subject to Change Statement

Information contained in the course syllabus, other than the grade policy, may be subject to change as deemed appropriate by the instructor.

Additional Policies & Where to Find Them

Further information on the following university policies can be found on the website below: academic integrity (i.e., plagiarism and any other forms of cheating); absence and class participation; accessibility and accommodations; non-discrimination and harassment; and the subject-to-change policy (i.e., what can be reasonably changed about the course with reasonably advance notice). Please familiarize yourself with these policies. <https://academicaffairs.arizona.edu/syllabus-policies>